

FLUID DRAPERY

The elegant language of drapery, and the way in which it both reveals and conceals the human form, was well understood by the stone carvers of Ancient Greece. They observed acutely the silhouettes achieved by tucking, folding, and draping combinations or sections of fabric that had been cut in triangles, squares, or circles.

Classical Greek drapery was a widespread and long-lasting style, in both fashion and art. It passed from Greece to Rome when Augustus (63BCE–14CE), the first Roman emperor, aspired to surpassing the achievements of the golden age of Greece. Retrospective styles in drapery flourished accordingly. Romans, of the upper classes at least, wore graceful, draped garments, but the influence of Greece was not confined to clothing. Fountains, sculpture, and monumental vases in the gardens and villas of wealthy Romans were invariably decorated with drapery styles borrowed from Greek sculpture of 500 years before.

In the modern world, from the 18th century onwards, a number of neoclassical movements in fashion have drawn on the soft, draped styles of the classical past. Often these have had a particular purpose – for example, helping to liberate women from the constraints of tight clothing and cumbersome layers of petticoats and shaped padding.

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The rectangle of fabric, when it is well chosen, is better for making the human form emerge. The angles form exterior parts which, in falling, rise up upon themselves in tiers and sinuous falls...

MADELEINE VIONNET, *GAZETTE DU BON TON*, 1924–25

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GREEK VOTIVE RELIEF, 410BCE ▷

Draped in flowing folds of stone, Artemis and her nymphs stand before a river god.

